Jay A Career

Game Design Document — Assignment 3: Storyline, Levels and UI

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Main menu: the live game world at dusk behind the menu.

Repository: https://github.com/amrelkotit/Jay-A-Career/tree/assignment-3

Prototype Video: *[video link inserted after upload]*

Unity 6000.3.24f1 · URP · branch assignment-3 · open Assets/JayACareer/Scenes/MainMenu.unity and press Play.

Contents: 1 Storyline · 2 Characters · 3 Narrative Structure · 4 Levels · 5 UI Design · 6 Implementation Plan · 7 Art & Audio · 8 Story in the Prototype · 9 Checklist & Credits

1. Storyline Summary

Jay A Career is a grounded, story-driven crime drama played from a first- or third-person view across three days in Calder Flats, a fictional dying desert town. The tone is quiet and tense: the danger comes from conversations, money and silence rather than combat. The core conflict is survival against loyalty. Jay, a broke twenty-three-year-old, finds an eviction notice on his door: $400 in three days or he loses his room. The only job on offer is across the road, in the rented laboratory of Dr. Elias Hale, a former industrial chemist the town gossips about but never visits.

Hale's rules are simple: seal the order at the preparation bench, carry the tamper-sealed carton across the road to the collection counter, take the money, clean the bench and say nothing. The product is never named or shown; every character simply calls it "the order". On the first morning the buyer is Leo, a nervous regular who pays $100 in small bills and lets a name slip: Paul. In Hale's desk Jay finds an old Corvane Industrial Chemicals staff badge with Hale's photo scratched out. Hale was somebody once.

On the second day dusk falls while Luka, a sharp middleman, makes his offer. This is the game's meaningful choice: accept Luka's $150, push for $250, or refuse him entirely. Each option changes Jay's cash, Hale's trust and the attention (Heat) on the operation, and Hale reacts differently afterwards. Whatever Jay chooses, a message on Luka's phone, signed only "P.", reveals that someone bigger is watching the old man's new boy.

The third day ends in darkness. Hale's lights are off and his coat is still on the hook. With a flashlight Jay searches the lab and finds a ledger of eight years of payments to "P.", an unsent letter to Hale's daughter and a forced lockbox holding a $480,000 court settlement. Hale returns and finally confesses: he took the blame for a colleague's accident at Corvane, lost his licence, and Paul bought the debt he could never pay. His tone (tired, frightened or proud) depends on what Jay did with Luka. Then Paul arrives in person, calm and polite, already knowing everything about the Luka deal. He pays for the night's order and slides a card

across the counter: "Tomorrow. Without the old man." The story closes on Jay holding the card while Hale watches from the lab doorway. Jay may have his rent. He no longer has a simple answer to the question that started it all: whose career is this?

2. Character Profiles

Profiles follow the lecture's Character Background Paper and Character Attributes (characterization and status). Portraits are rendered from the in-game models and appear in the dialogue box.



Jay — protagonist (player avatar)

Background: 23, grew up in Calder Flats, dropped out of technical college and lives on odd jobs. Quick, sarcastic when nervous, honest underneath.

Motivation: Keep his room and prove he is more than "the kid who never finished anything". Fear: ending up exactly where he started.

Role and relation to the player: The player is Jay; every choice is his. Hero's Journey arc: ordinary world (eviction) → call (Hale's job) → threshold (first carton) → tests (Luka) → revelation (Hale's notes) → reward and new dilemma (Paul's card). Status attributes in game: Cash, Trust, Heat, Day.



Dr. Elias Hale — mentor

Background: 58, former senior chemist at Corvane Industrial Chemicals. Took the blame for a colleague's accident, lost his job and licence, and now runs a small rented lab.

Motivation: Pay off the settlement Paul owns, keep Paul away from his life and, one day, reconnect with his daughter Clara. Fear: ruining someone else's life a second time.

Role and relation to the player: Mentor / Wise Old Man archetype with a shadow. Precise, formal speech, long pauses. Teaches Jay, hides the truth, then confesses in Level 3; his trust is a visible HUD meter that the player's choices move.



Leo — buyer, Level 1

Background: Thirties, grey hoodie, hands in pockets. Jittery, polite, talks too much and pays in small bills.

Motivation: Get his order and leave before anyone important notices him.

Role and relation to the player: Tutorial buyer: a safe first deal that teaches the hand-off. Narrative hook: lets the name "Paul" slip (optional question).



Luka — buyer, Level 2

Background: Late twenties, red jacket, confident and impatient; charming until he is not.

Motivation: Collect cheaply for his boss and test the new boy.

Role and relation to the player: Middleman and the meaningful choice. His phone reveals that "P." is watching Jay.



Paul — buyer, Level 3

Background: Fifties, shaved head, dark waistcoat over an open collar, very still. Calm, polite and patient; never threatens directly.

Motivation: Keep Hale in debt and recruit Jay without him.

Role and relation to the player: Antagonist and climax. Reacts to how Jay treated Luka and delivers the cliffhanger offer.

3. Narrative Structure

The plot uses the lecture's three-act Story Units: Act 1 hook (Level 1), Act 2 hold (Level 2), Act 3 payoff (Level 3). Each act is broken into sequences, scenes and beats (beat table, §6.1). The Story Phases map as exposition (intro, briefing), rising action (Leo, the badge, Luka's warning), midpoint (Luka's deal and the "P." message), climax (confession and Paul) and an open resolution (the card).

Branching follows the foldback (branch-and-bottleneck) structure from the Week 7 lecture: the Luka choice branches into three outcomes that reconverge at Paul, but the branch keeps paying off in later content — Hale's reaction, the recap between levels, Hale's confession, Paul's opening line, the final cash and the end-screen summary. Objectives always come from the story state, so the dramatic tension curve rises steadily: morning safety, dusk pressure, night danger.

Level	Emotional arc	Key plot points
Level 1	Desperation → relief → curiosity	Eviction notice; easy money from Leo; Hale's scratched-out badge.
Level 2	Pressure → agency → unease	Luka's offer; the player's choice; the "P." message as the street lamps flicker on.
Level 3	Dread → empathy → shock	Dark lab search; Hale's confession; Paul's calm offer and the card.

Hero's Journey stage	In Jay A Career
Ordinary world / call	Eviction notice; Hale's job offer (L1 intro and briefing)
Crossing the threshold	Sealing and delivering the first carton to Leo
Tests, allies, enemies	Luka's deal; the "P." message (L2)
Ordeal / revelation	Searching Hale's lab; the confession (L3)
Reward and new challenge	Paul's money and the card: "Tomorrow. Without the old man."

4. Level Descriptions

Level 1 — First Delivery (Act 1 · morning)

Narrative role: Introduces Jay, Hale and the rules of the work, and plants the mystery of Hale's past.

Narrative moments: Opening cutscene; Hale's briefing; sealing the first carton; Leo's deal (optional question reveals "Paul"); end-of-day reflection.

Environmental storytelling: Eviction notice and a calendar with three red circles on Jay's wall; unpaid bills on his desk; Corvane badge and a face-down cracked safety award in the lab; dust and stains showing the lab was once busier. Street lamps switch off one by one as the sun rises.

Unique mechanic and gate: First hand-off: carry, place on the counter, a tutorial deal. Gate: sleeping after cleaning sets act1Complete → recap → Level 2.



Level 1: Leo at the counter in the morning light.

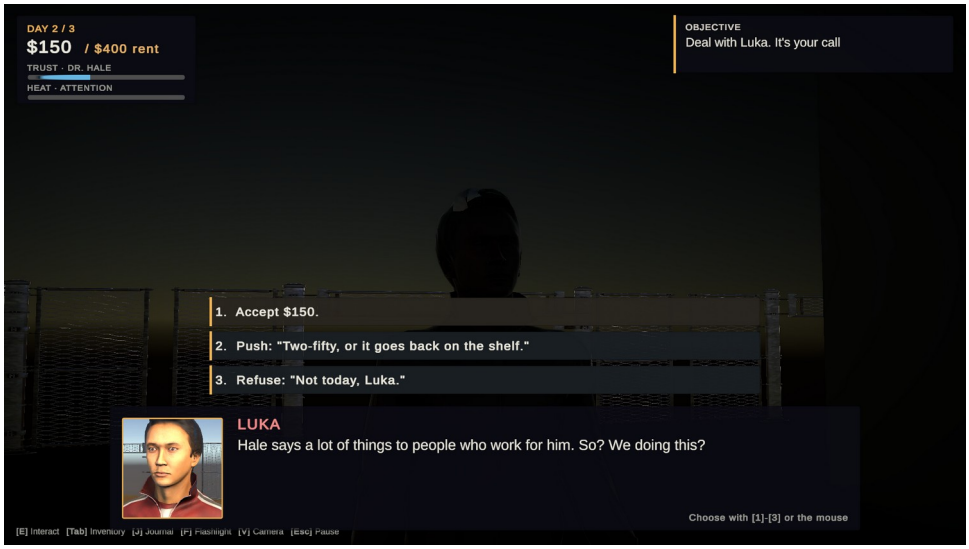
Level 2 — The Middleman (Act 2 · dusk)

Narrative role: Raises the stakes with a buyer who pushes back and reveals a bigger player.

Narrative moments: Hale's warning; Luka's deal (the meaningful choice); Luka's reaction; the "P." message; Hale's reaction (three variants); reflection.

Environmental storytelling: Fresh tyre tracks and oil where a car waited; cigarette butts by the counter; the street lamps flicker on mid-deal as the colour grade shifts to orange.

Unique mechanic and gate: Choice with visible consequences on Cash, Trust and Heat; refusing sends the carton back to the shelf. Gate: act2Complete after sleep → recap (three variants) → Level 3.



Level 2: Luka's offer at dusk — the meaningful choice, with each option's consequence spelled out.

Level 3 — The Big Buyer (Act 3 · night)

Narrative role: Pays off every thread: Hale's past, the choice and Paul.

Narrative moments: Jay wakes at midnight; empty lab; three clues; Hale's confession; Paul's arrival and offer; ending cutscene.

Environmental storytelling: Hale's lab fixtures are off for the first time ("The lights are off at Hale's") and only come on when he walks back in; Hale's coat on the hook, forced lockbox, headlights at the end of the road, a warm light spilling from the lab doorway in the final shot; cold blue grade.

Unique mechanic and gate: Flashlight search for three clues (counter-based trigger) before Hale returns. Gate: paulMet → ending cutscene → end screen.

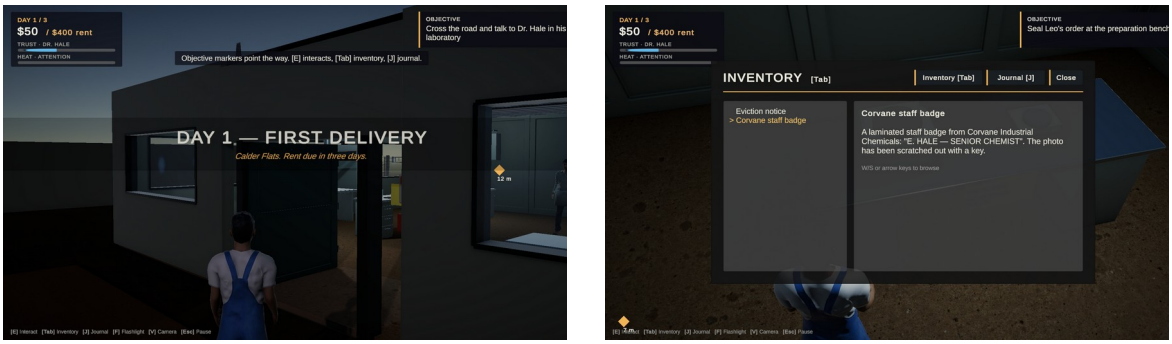


Level 3: Hale's confession after he switches the lab lights back on.

5. UI Design Concept

Element	Design	Story information it delivers
Dialogue box	Speaker name in the character's colour, portrait, typewriter text, up to three numbered choices.	Who is speaking and what they want; choices state their consequence in plain words ("Accept $150").
Objective tracker	Top-right panel with a "NEW OBJECTIVE" flash and an on-screen marker with distance.	The current story goal, derived from the story state, so it never goes out of sync.
Status indicators	Day 1/3, Cash with the $400 rent goal, Trust (Dr. Hale) and Heat bars.	The core conflict at a glance: money against loyalty and attention.
Inventory [Tab] / Journal [J]	Notebook with tabs: collected lore items and written clues.	Environmental storytelling the player chose to discover (badge, phone message, ledger, letter).
Prompts & toasts	Contextual "[E] ..." prompt; short messages for feedback.	Signs & feedback (lecture): every interaction confirms what happened.
Menus & loading	Main menu over the live world at dusk; pause (resume, restart day, settings); loading recap between levels; end screen.	Narrative progress markers: each recap summarises consequences and the next stakes.

Design follows the lecture's UI principles: visual hierarchy (objective and dialogue strongest), contrast (off-white on dark translucent panels, one amber accent), consistency (one font, one panel style), minimal clutter (HUD hides during cutscenes and dialogue), and diegetic support (the street lamps, calendar and eviction notice carry information inside the world). Subtitles accompany every line and their size is adjustable.



Left: HUD — status (day, cash vs rent, trust, heat), objective tracker, marker, tutorial hint and chapter card. Right: inventory with lore descriptions (Tab).

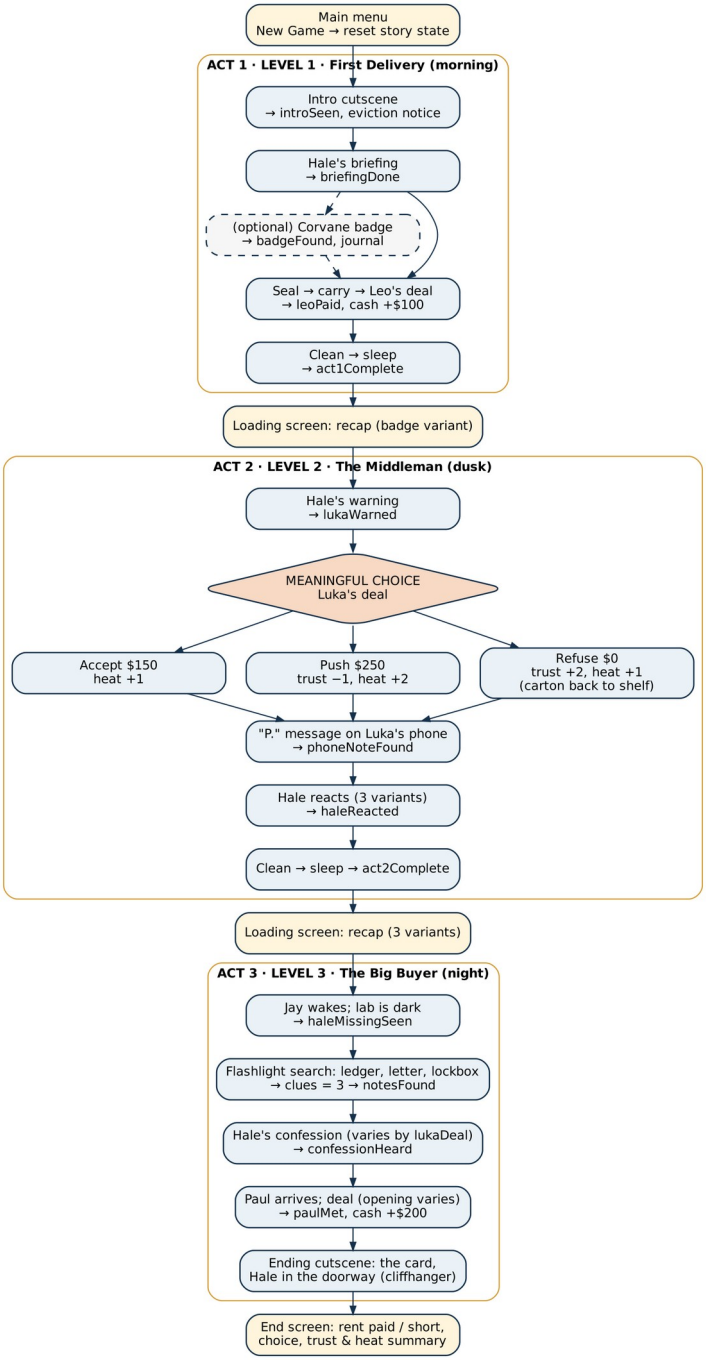
6. Storyline Implementation Plan

6.1 Story beat table

#	Beat	Level	Trigger	UI shown	State change
1	Eviction notice	L1	Intro cutscene (auto)	Subtitles	introSeen, item
2	Meet Hale	L1	Talk [E]	Dialogue + portrait	briefingDone
3	Corvane badge	L1	Pick up	Inventory + journal	badgeFound
4	Seal first carton	L1	Bench [E]	Prompt, toast	cartonSealed
5	Leo's deal	L1	Counter + talk	Dialogue choices	leoPaid, +$100

#	Beat	Level	Trigger	UI shown	State change
6	End of day 1	L1→L2	Sleep	Loading recap	act1Complete
7	Hale's warning	L2	Talk [E]	Dialogue	lukaWarned
8	Dusk falls	L2	Carton delivered	Lamps, grade	lukaArrived
9	THE CHOICE	L2	Dialogue choice	Choices + bars	lukaDeal, trust/heat
10	"P." message	L2	Inspect phone	Journal	phoneNoteFound
11	Hale reacts	L2→L3	Talk; sleep	Dialogue variant	haleReacted, act2Complete
12	Dark lab	L3	Enter zone	Inner monologue	haleMissingSeen
13	Search	L3	3 pickups	Inventory	clues=3 → notesFound
14	Confession	L3	Talk [E]	Dialogue variant	confessionHeard
15	Paul	L3	Counter + talk	Dialogue variant	paulMet, +$200
16	The card	L3	Ending cutscene	Cutscene, end screen	endingSeen

6.2 Flowchart



Foldback structure: one meaningful choice branches in Act 2 and reconverges at Paul, with consequences carried forward.

6.3 Story flags and variables

Flags / variables	Meaning
introSeen / briefingDone / badgeFound	Opening cutscene seen; Hale's briefing done; badge collected (optional).
cartonSealed / leoPaid / act1Complete	First order sealed; Leo paid; day 1 over → load Level 2.
lukaWarned / lukaDealt / lukaDeal	Warning heard; choice made; text value accepted / pushed / refused.
phoneNoteFound / haleReacted / act2Complete	"P." clue found; Hale's reaction heard; day 2 over → load Level 3.
haleMissingSeen / clues (int) / notesFound	Entered the dark lab; clues found 0–3; all three found → Hale returns.
confessionHeard / paulMet / endingSeen	Confession done; Paul paid → ending cutscene; end screen reached.
cash · trust · heat · day (ints)	HUD values; trust and heat clamped 0–5; rent goal $400.

6.4 Dialogue format and scripts

Dialogue is stored as ScriptableObjects (DialogueData): each asset holds lines (speaker profile, text, optional conditions), choices (text, conditions, effects, loop action, payment, follow-up conversation) and completion effects — the lecture's dialogue tree with preconditions and actions. Characters keep a prioritised list of conversations; the first whose preconditions pass is played. ScriptableObjects were chosen because they are native to Unity, editable in the Inspector without code, need no extra package (unlike Ink or Yarn) and keep story content out of game logic, avoiding the brief's common mistake of hard-coded dialogue.

Script	Responsibility
StoryStateManager	Flags, integers and texts across scenes; OnFlagSet event; level snapshot for restart.
DialogueData / CharacterProfile	ScriptableObject conversations and speaker profiles (name, colour, portrait).
DialogueManager	Typewriter dialogue box, choices, follow-ups, effects, play-once handling.
ObjectiveManager	Derives the current objective from the story state.
StoryTrigger / LoreItem	Fire-once beats (zone, start, condition) and interactive lore objects.
LevelDirector	Per-level pacing, loop-to-story mapping, story-driven time of day, gated transitions.
CutsceneController	Timeline + Cinemachine cutscenes, subtitles, hold-to-skip, finish actions.
LevelTransitionManager / LoadingScreenController	Story-gated scene loading with recap screen.
StoryHUD / NotebookUI / menus / SettingsManager	HUD, inventory & journal, main/pause/end menus, saved settings.
StreetLampController	Lamps switch on at dusk and off at dawn, one by one, with a flicker.
JayPlayerController / JayGameManager (extended)	Movement, single [E] interaction, delivery loop raising story events.

Verification: an automated playthrough (Assignment3AutoPilot) plays the game from the main menu to the end screen through each Luka branch and checks every beat, flag,

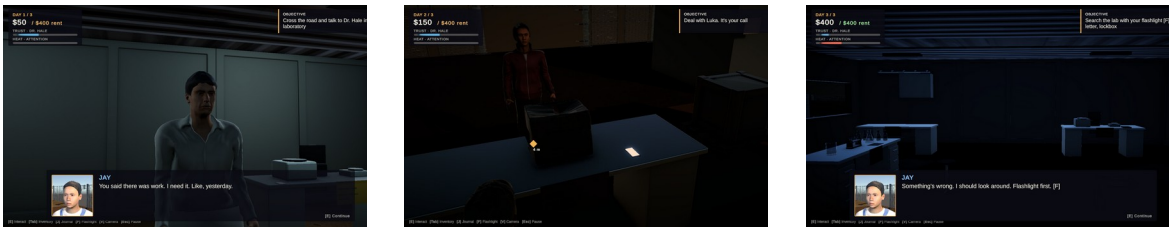
cash/trust/heat value and transition — 191 checks, all passing (reports in the repository under Deliverables/Evidence/Assignment3).

7. Art and Aesthetic Style

Visual style: grounded realism in Unity URP — photoscanned CC0 props, realistic humans, physically based materials, a per-act colour grade (warm sunrise, orange dusk, cold blue night), white balance, contrast, bloom and vignette set per act in URP volumes, and worn surfaces (stains, oil, tyre tracks) so every space looks used.

Colour script: amber marks safety and story UI; the desert is warm in Act 1; Act 2 shifts to orange as the lamps turn on; Act 3 is blue-black, lit only by the flashlight, the lamps and the warm doorway in the final shot.

Audio: ambient outdoor and lab ambience plus footsteps (synthesised for the project), a Kenney interface chime when a conversation opens, and a Kenney impact sound for placing cartons and confirming dialogue choices. Lighting carries the mood more than music: the dark lab on Day 3 is broken only by the flashlight and the lamps outside.



Colour script: lit lab in the morning (Hale's briefing), orange dusk with the lamps on (Luka's deal), cold blue night in the dark lab (Day 3).

8. Story in the Prototype (video timestamps)

Time	Story beat shown in the video
00:00	Main menu
00:07	Loading screen: Day 1 recap
00:16	L1_FirstDelivery starts
00:16	Opening cutscene (Timeline + Cinemachine)
00:43	Dr. Hale's briefing
01:38	Lore: Hale's Corvane badge
02:08	Seal the order at the preparation bench
02:11	Carry the carton across the road
02:24	Leo's deal (asks about Paul first)
03:55	Clean the bench
04:20	Sleep: the day ends
04:29	Loading screen: Day 2 recap
04:37	L2_Middleman starts
04:41	Hale warns about Luka
05:27	Seal the order at the preparation bench

Time	Story beat shown in the video
05:30	Carry the carton across the road
05:43	Dusk falls: street lamps switch on
05:51	Luka's deal — meaningful choice: pushed
06:33	Clue: the "P." message on Luka's phone
06:53	Hale reacts to the choice
07:27	Clean the bench
07:50	Sleep: the day ends
07:58	Loading screen: Day 3 recap
08:07	L3_BigBuyer starts
08:18	Jay walks to the dark lab
08:40	Flashlight search: ledger, letter, lockbox
09:26	Hale's confession (varies with the Luka choice)
10:23	Seal the order at the preparation bench
10:26	Carry the carton across the road
10:39	Paul's deal and offer
11:21	Closing cutscene: the card and Hale in the doorway
11:45	End screen: consequences summary

9. Requirements Checklist and Credits

Brief requirement	Where
≥3 playable story levels, menu, intro and ending	MainMenu, L1, L2, L3, Ending; Timeline intro and ending (§4, §8)
≥3 narrative moments per level; story-driven objectives	Beat table §6.1; ObjectiveManager
Story state, meaningful choice, gated transitions	StoryStateManager; Luka choice; LevelDirector (§6)
Environmental storytelling; interactive narrative elements	Lore items, decals, lamps, props (§4)
Dialogue box with name and portrait; objectives; status; inventory; journal	§5
≥6 commented scripts, ≥2 narrative	19 story scripts (§6.4)
Links, timestamps, file name	Title page; §8; ElKotit_Amr_GDD.pdf

• Environment and props: Poly Haven models and textures (CC0); ModKit v1.2 modules (CC0); original Blender models of the lab and bedroom (A2).
• Dr. Hale and Jay: MakeHuman / MPFB humans (CC0) with original animation clips; sounds: Kenney Impact and Interface Sounds (CC0) and original synthesised ambience.
• Leo, Luka and Paul: Microsoft Rocketbox avatars (MIT licence) — Male_Adult_18, Male_Adult_10, Business_Male_04.
• Engine and packages: Unity 6000.3.24f1, URP 17.3, Cinemachine 3.1.5, Timeline, TextMeshPro, Input System, Unity Recorder.
• Decals, calendar and eviction-notice textures: generated procedurally for this project.
• All characters, places, companies and products are fictional. No real chemistry is shown or described.